



Faxonius immunis
(calico crayfish)
Crustaceans-Crayfish
Native Transplant

 Collection Info

 Point Map

 Species Profile

 Animated Map



Chris Lukhaup, courtesy the Missouri Department of Conservation © 

Faxonius immunis (Hagen, 1870)

Common name: calico crayfish

Synonyms and Other Names: *Orconectes immunis* (Hagen, 1870), Paper shell crayfish (Smith 2013). *Faxonius immunis* underwent a reclassification in August 2017, changing the genus of non-cave dwelling *Orconectes* to *Faxonius* (Crandall and De Grave 2017).

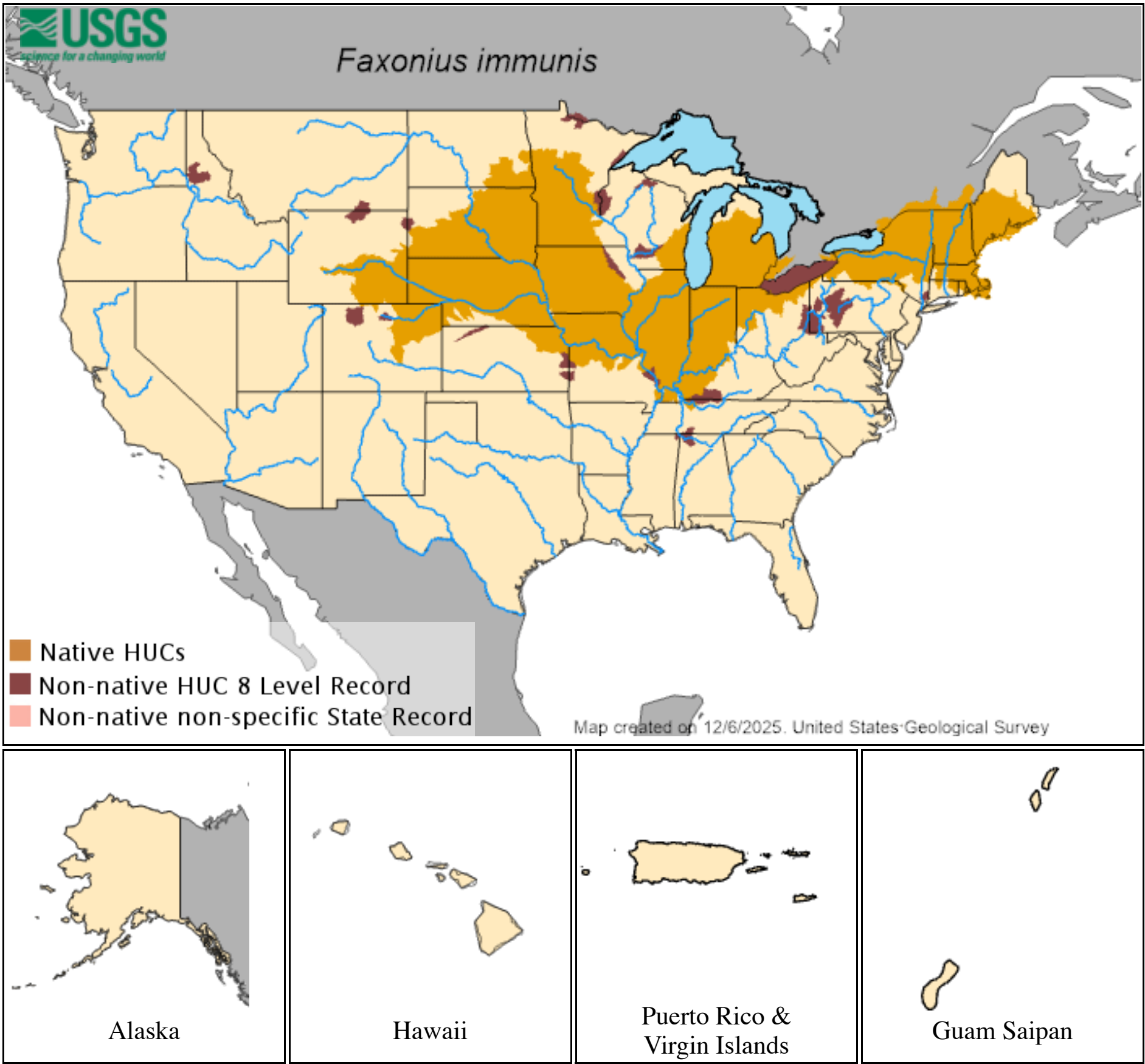
Taxonomy: available through 

Identification: The calico crayfish is a plain, grey-green species characterized by a pale zone in the middle of the carapace and abdomen. Their chelipeds (pincers) have orange tips, with the exception of male chelipids that usually display a pale purple tint as breeding regalia (Smith 2013).

Size: 1.7 - 3.5 inches total length (Pflieger, 1987)

Native Range: Lakes Erie, Ontario, Huron, and Southern Lake Michigan, lower Ohio, and upper Mississippi drainages. Massachusetts to Wyoming and Alabama to Ontario, Canada (Hobbs, 1974).

This species extends as far east as Maine and Connecticut, and as far west as eastern Colorado and Wyoming. It's northernmost range includes southern Manitoba, Ontario and Quebec; It's southernmost range extends to Kentucky (Adams et al. 2010).



Hydrologic Unit Codes (HUCs) Explained
Interactive maps: [Point Distribution Maps](#)

Nonindigenous Occurrences:

Table 1. States with nonindigenous occurrences, the earliest and latest observations in each state, and the tally and names of [HUCs](#) with observations†. Names and dates are hyperlinked to their relevant specimen records. The list of references for all nonindigenous occurrences of *Faxonius immunis* are found [here](#).

State	First Observed	Last Observed	Total HUCs with observations†	HUCs with observations†
CO	1982	2009	2	Big Thompson ; Upper Yampa
CT	1989	1989	1	New England Region
ID	2014	2014	1	Clearwater
IL	1973	1980	1	Upper Mississippi-Cape Girardeau
IA	1977	2013	2	Upper Cedar ; Upper Wapsipinicon
KY	1998	1999	2	Barren ; Red
MN	2006	2011	2	Beaver-Lester ; Lower Rainy
MS	1977	1977	1	Pickwick Lake
MO	1983	1987	2	Lower Marais Des Cygnes ; Marmaton
NE	2004	2004	1	Prairie Dog
NY	1996	1996	1	Lower Hudson
PA	1961	2014	10	Clarion ; Conemaugh ; Connoquenessing ; Lake Erie ; Lower Monongahela ; Middle Allegheny-Redbank ; Monongahela ; Upper Ohio ; Upper Ohio-Wheeling ; Upper West Branch Susquehanna
SD	1995	1995	1	Redwater
WI	1981	2020	3	Flambeau ; Lower St. Croix ; Lower Wisconsin
WY	1995	1995	1	Upper Tongue

Table last updated 12/8/2025

† Populations may not be currently present.

Ecology: Found in shallow ditches and sloughs of medium to large rivers with plenty of aquatic plants and plant debris for cover; mud bottoms with stagnant water; can tolerate high turbidity; a burrower that will move from pond to pond. They are considered a generalist species with a broad ecological niche, however they are not able to colonise fast flowing streams (Adams et al., 2010). Breeding occurs in late summer in New York and eggs are laid in the spring (U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service 2015).

Means of Introduction: Sold as bait; probable bait bucket introduction (U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service 2015). Outside the United states, introduction is unclear; Schrimpf et al. (2013) suggests this species has spread via pet trades as well as bait bucket releases.

Status: Unknown.

Impact of Introduction: The impacts of this species are currently unknown, as no studies have been done to determine how it has affected ecosystems in the invaded range. The absence of data does not equate to lack of effects. It does, however, mean that research is required to evaluate effects before conclusions can be made.

References (click for full references)

Adams, S., G. A. Schuster, and C. A. Taylor. 2010. *Orconectes immunis*. The IUCN Red List of Threatened Species, version 2015.1. Available at: <http://www.iucnredlist.org/details/153925/0>.

Crandall, K.A. and S. De Grave. 2017. An updated classification of the freshwater crayfishes (Decapoda: Astacidea) of the world, with a complete species list. Journal of Crustacean Biology 37(5):615-653. <https://doi.org/10.1093/jebiol/rux070>.

Hobbs, H. H., Jr. 1974. A checklist of the North and Middle American crayfishes (Decpoda: Astacidae and Cambaridae). Smithsonian Institution Press.

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Schrimpf, A., C. Chucholl, T. Schmidt, and R. Schultz. 2013. Crayfish plague agent detected in populations of the invasive North American crayfish *Orconectes immunis* (Hagen, 1870) in the Rhine River, Germany. Aquatic Invasions 8(1):103-109.

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U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service. 2015. *Orconectes immunis*. Available at: <https://www.fws.gov/fisheries/ans/erss/uncertainrisk/Orconectes-immunis-ERSS-June2015.pdf>

Other Resources:

[The Crandall Lab](#)

[Great Lakes Waterlife](#)

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